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Section Title(S)

The Names of the Lesser God • The Names of the Wives of the Gods

The Names of the Lesser God

The great god named the lesser god by giving him all of his own 'divine' names but not his human name, ≠*Gao!na*.

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Having been named for the great god, the lesser god is the great god's namesake, his *!guma* (*!gu* is name, *ma* is small or younger), and the great god is the *!gu!na* (*!na* means old, older, or big).

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The concept of the namesake, and of the relationship between the *!gu!na* and the *!guma*, is an important one in the !Kung kinship system.¹ *!Gu!na* and *!guma* are always of the same sex, !Kung names being sex-linked. One shares in some mystical way the entity of the person for whom one is named. Incest taboos require that one must not marry the parent or offspring of one's *!gu!na* or *!guma*. Behaviour between a *!gu!na* and a *!guma* is as open and free from formal restrictions as any in !Kung society. They have the joking relationship. Only the usual respect of the young for the old is expected.

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The opposite conditions exist between parent and child. A man must not name a son for himself or a daughter for her mother. Parent and offspring do not have the joking relationship.

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It was interesting to me to find the great and lesser god in the *!gu!na—!guma* relationship rather than the father—son relationship, as it offers some evidence that the concept of the two gods is not influenced by the Christian concept of God, the father, and Jesus, the son. Also one comes to see that the father-son relationship would not serve the Bushmen as well as the *!gu!na—!guma* relationship in explaining the problem of evil, for a son would not present as sharp a duality, but, according to human standards, would express respect, obedience, deference, propriety, and assistance, which is not *in total* the function of the lesser god.

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The Names of the Wives of the Gods

The Nyae Nyae !Kung believe that *≠Gao!na* gave all his own 'divine' names to both of the wives; *di*, the suffix which means 'female' is added: *Hishedi*, *Huwedi*, *Kxodi*, *!Garadi*, *Gani gadi*, *≠Gaishi* *≠gaidi*, *//Gauwadi*.

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≠Gao!na, the great god's human name, is not applied to the wives, men's names never being given to women. One would say instead *≠Gao!na a tsau*, '*≠Gao!na* his wife'.

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Each wife has a human name as well. The elder one, who usually lives alone with *≠Gao!na*, is named *Khwova!na*, Old Khwova. The younger one is *//Gow*. (*//Gow* rhymes with *how*. The *ao* sound in the men's names *Gao*, *≠Gao*, and */Gao* I use arbitrarily and mean by it a slightly shorter, more closed sound, like the *ou* in *ouch*.) We knew only two women named *//Gow* but knew many Khwovas.

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The wives of the gods may be referred to or addressed by a respect term, used  226 only for females, *kolidi*, a term which one may also apply to women when one wants to be especially polite and to honour them. It is used for women 'who possess lots of things', the !Kung explained. *Gaoxadi*, the female form of one of the respect terms for the gods, may also be applied.

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¹ Cf. Lorna Marshall, 'The Kin Terminology System of the !Kung Bushmen', *Africa*, vol. xxvii, no. 1, Jan. 1957, pp. 1–25.

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